

Saudi Arabia

 The largest and most important country in the Arabian Peninsula, Saudi Arabia is 95 per cent hot, dry, and inhospitable desert. The most populated areas lie along the Gulf and Red Sea coasts. Founded in 1922 by Ibn Saud, Saudi Arabia has grown wealthy as a result of its vast oil reserves, discovered in 1938. It has major refining and petrochemical industries and spends freely on farming, education, and agriculture.

Riyadh

Saudi Arabia's capital since 1932, Riyadh is a modern city of around two million people. Lying among oases of orchards and palm groves, it is the centre of Saudi Arabia's commerce and government. Buildings range from smart, modern skyscrapers, erected since 1950, to poor shacks.



Saudi-Cairo Bank



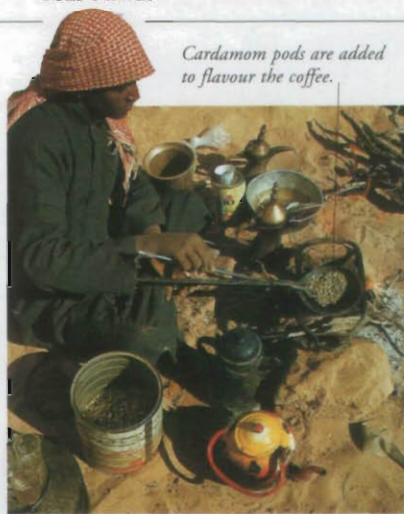
People

Most Saudi people are Muslim Arabs. They take their religion seriously and interpret the Qur'an, the Islamic holy book, strictly. Women must wear veils and may not drive cars. However, about 33 per cent of schoolchildren are girls, and women may take certain jobs, such as nursing and teaching.



Mecca (Makkah)

Every year, two million Muslims visit the Ka'ba shrine in the Great Mosque at Mecca, birthplace of Muhammad and Islamic holy city. All Muslims should make a pilgrimage, or *hajj*, to Mecca at least once in their lives.



Cardamom pods are added to flavour the coffee.

Bedouin

Nomadic Bedouin roam the vast desert, grazing their camels, sheep, and goats in oases. They live in portable tents, but the government is trying to persuade them to give up their wandering life to settle in cities.



Lentils Dates

Farming

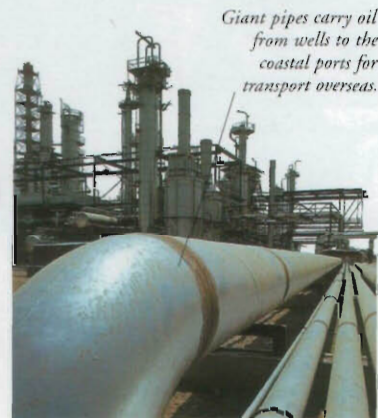
Massive irrigation projects using desalinated sea water to irrigate vast, circular fields now make it possible for Saudi farmers to cultivate wheat, fruit, and vegetables. Farming employs one-eighth of the work-force.



Tomato

SAUDI ARABIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Riyadh
AREA	2,149,690 sq km (829,995 sq miles)
POPULATION	21,600,000
DENSITY	10 per sq km (26 per sq mile)
MAIN LANGUAGE	Arabic
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Saudi riyal
LIFE EXPECTANCY	71 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	588
GOVERNMENT	Absolute monarchy
ADULT LITERACY	77%



Giant pipes carry oil from wells to the coastal ports for transport overseas.

Oilfields

Saudi Arabia has the world's biggest oil and gas reserves – a quarter of the world's total – and is the world's leading oil exporter. Income from oil has improved living standards.

Yemen

 Formerly two separate countries, Yemen was united in 1990. The north is mountainous, with a narrow, fertile coastal strip on the Red Sea coast, where cotton and grapes are grown. The arid Rub' al Khali desert, or "Empty Quarter" covers the northeast. Yemen's main source of income is oil, some of which is refined in the port of Aden.



Traditional coffee pot

Coffee

Yemen produces fine coffee beans, and coffee drinking is thought to have originated here. Mocha coffee is named after the port of Al-Makha from where it was exported. Yemenis chew *qat*, shoots of a narcotic shrub, with coffee.



Sana

Yemen's modern capital, Sana, sits in the centre of the country, 2,380 m (7,808 ft) above sea-level. With a population of about half a million, it is a modern commercial and industrial centre with historic buildings, markets (*souks*), and ornately decorated mosques.

YEMEN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Sana
AREA	527,970 sq km (203,849 sq miles)
POPULATION	18,100,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Arabic
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Yemeni rial

Oman

 Ruled by a sultan, the Sultanate of Oman is mostly desert, with a narrow fertile strip along the Gulf of Oman in the north, where most of the people live. Oil has brought the country great prosperity. About 75 per cent of the people belong to the Islamic Ibadi sect, which adopts a liberal attitude towards women. Pakistani Baluchis make up one-quarter of Omanis.

OMAN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Muscat
AREA	212,460 sq km (82,030 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Arabic, Baluchi
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, Hindu
CURRENCY	Omani rial



Sardines

Anchovy

Fishing

Omani fishermen catch 118,000 tonnes of fish a year in the rich waters of the Arabian Sea and Gulf of Oman. The main catches are anchovies, cod, cuttlefish, sardines, and tuna. The country exports dried fish and fish meal.

City of the sands

Archaeologists have discovered the remains of a city, believed to have been built in about 3000 BC, buried beneath the sands of southern Oman. They think it may be the remains of the legendary lost Arabian city of Ubar.

